I. Title of Proposal: **ESTABLISHMENT OF PARTIDO STATE UNIVERSITY RESEARCH ETHICS COMMITTEE (PSUREC)**

II. Proponent: **DIOMERL EDWARD BALDO**
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III. RATIONALE:

Research ethics committees (REC) review proposed studies with human participants to ensure that they conform to internationally and locally accepted ethical guidelines, monitor studies once they have begun, and take part in follow up action and surveillance after the end of the research. Committees have the authority to approve, reject or stop studies or require modifications to research protocols. The REC is a key element of University administration and has gained increasing importance as a review mechanism for those institutions that wish to conduct responsible research along with safeguarding research ethics standard and scientific merit (Davies, 2020).

Research ethics committees have an important role to play in ensuring the ethical standards and scientific merit of research involving human subjects. There are three important obligations placed on the ethics committee. Firstly, and most importantly, the ethics committee must ensure that the rights of research participants are protected. Secondly, the research ethics committee has an obligation to society which provides the resources for research and will ultimately be affected by the results. Thirdly, the research ethics committee has an obligation to the researcher. The research proposal should be treated with respect and consideration.

It is essential to recognize that while the dominant discourse and development of regulatory frameworks may have been driven by health and biomedical disciplines, it is equally important to acknowledge that, although research methodologies and analytical paradigms may differ, all research, including social science research and trans-disciplinary research must be judged against the same ethical principles' (South Africa DOH, 2004).

Ethics review by a research ethics committee is required by international ethical standards governing research involving human participants, as well as by local law in many jurisdictions (WHO, 2019), thus the efforts to comply with the pertinent documents to the Philippine Research Ethics Board (PHREB) for the accreditation of a Level 1 academic institution-based REC (AI-REC) which shall be named Partido State University Research Ethics Committee (PSUREC).

State Universities and Colleges are authorized by law/charter to conduct research and extension services, including projects that will improve and intensify the government's existing COVID-19 responses. The University President in his reports had identified the efforts undertaken by CHED such as mobilizing HEIs to assist in the production and distribution of items (such as disinfectants, alcohol, face shields, etc.,) for use by frontline service providers. More is expected to SUCs in these trying times. The efforts to these types of researches can be realized if the protocol has been reviewed by an accredited research ethics committee.

The Ethics Review Committee also form a vital part in the PSU University Research, Extension and Knowledge Management Organizational Structure (Fig.1).

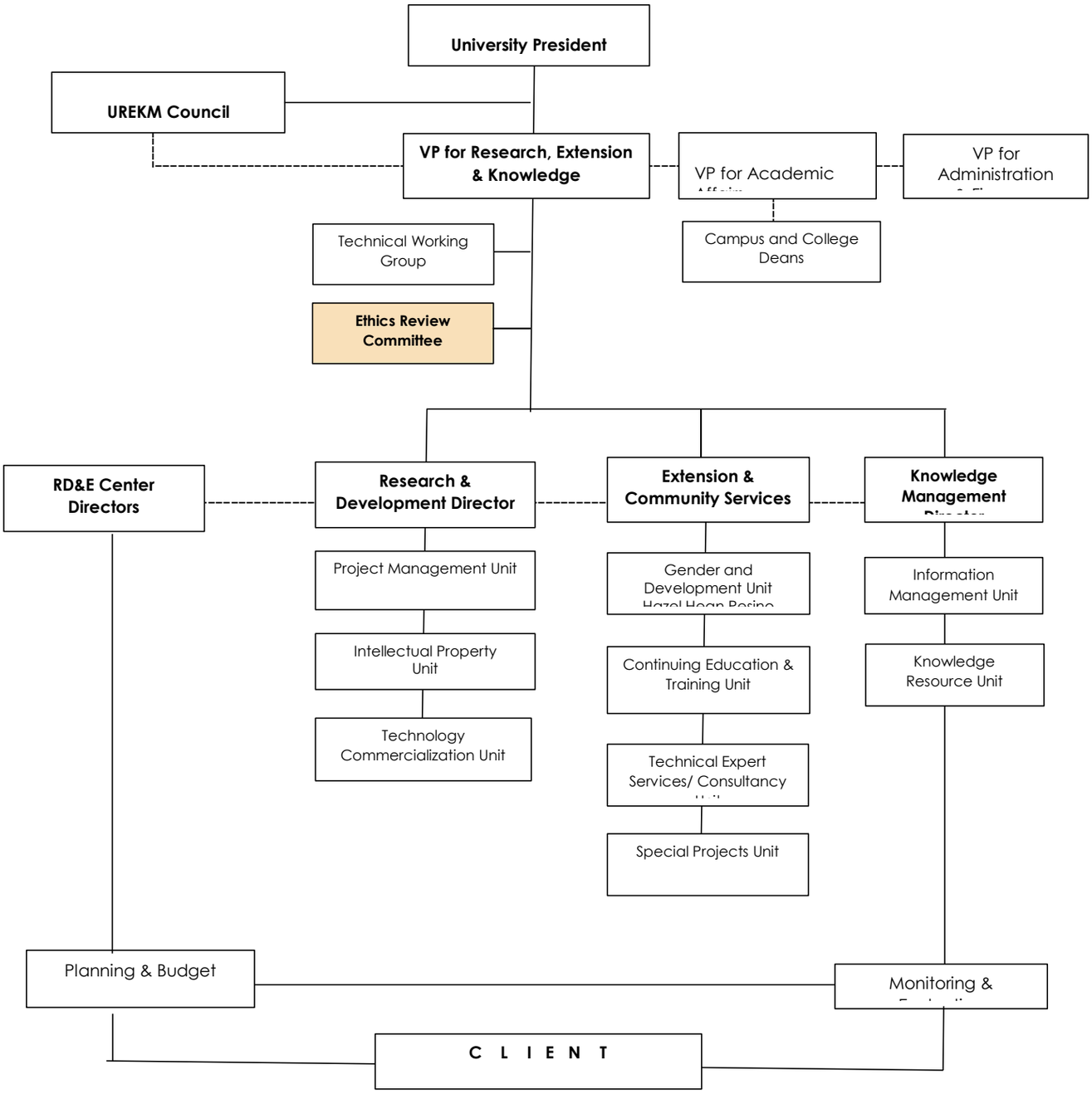


Figure 1. University Research, Extension and Knowledge Management Organizational Structure

IV. OBJECTIVES:

The PSUREC aims to:

1. Safeguard, the dignity, right, well-being and safety of all research participants including those undertaking the research either as investigators or research assistants;
2. Ensure that all research protocols submitted to the PSUREC for implementation meet the ethical standards set forth by international and local guidelines, laws and policies;

3. Undertake a balanced assessment of the risk and benefits involved in any research undertaking;
4. Promote integrity of research data by making independent decisions regarding a protocol review.

V. THE PROPOSAL

A. OPERATIONAL PLAN

The first year of the committee's operation will be in accordance with the limitations prescribed as a Level 1 Accredited REC. The committee can receive and evaluate research protocols from student researchers and other external entities The committee shall take responsibility on the following key activities:

1. Posting of PHREB Accreditation Certificate

A REC shall post or display its duly-secured certificate of PHREB accreditation in a conspicuous area within its office.

2. Submission of Annual Report within the first quarter of the following year using the PHREB Form No. 1.2: Annual Report which will reflect the following:

a. changes in committee chair and membership;
b. trainings attended by current members;
c. number and type of protocols reviewed, approved, revised, and disapproved;
d. summary of recognitions received by the REC or significant events that have affected the performance of its duties; and
e. Challenges / issues encountered.

3. Reporting of any controversial or important ethical issues in the course of its work

4. Apply for renewal by complying with the requirements/responsibilities of accredited RECs before the expiration of the accreditation.

B. COMMITTEE

1. Chairperson

The chairperson is responsible to chair the meetings and liaise directly with the head of the Institute, report the meeting outcomes to the University President, invite independent consultants to provide special expertise to the PSUREC on proposed research protocol. The Chair shall review and sign along with the member secretary all the minutes, proposals and work towards the smooth function of the committee.

Other specific duties include:

a. Represents the committee on the research organizational structure of PSUREC.
b. Recommends policy amendments and changes.
c. Prepares the budget and proposes membership.
d. Oversees the operations of the PSUREC Members.
e. Acts on suggestions, complaints and queries from stakeholders

2. Co-Chairperson

The co-chairperson is responsible to chair the meetings in the absence of the Chairperson and act as alternate Chair during meetings.

3. Member Secretary

The member secretary is responsible for the administrative aspect of the PSUREC.

4. Secretariat

The Secretariat is composed of the Member Secretary and the administrative supporting staff who has knowledge in basic ethics and act as lower division clerk. It is mandatory that the clerical assistant and peon should be a permanent employee to ensure efficient record keeping and retrieval of documents. The supporting staff are appointed by the University President.

The Secretariat shall have the following functions:

a. Organize PSUREC meetings regularly
b. Preparation and maintenance of meeting agenda and minutes
c. Receive and check for the completeness of the documents for review by the PSUREC
d. Arrange the Committee Members' meeting for finalization of the Participant Information Sheet and Informed Consent Form (*Assent information sheet and assent form wherever applicable*).

5. PSUREC Members

a. The role of the scientific and/or medical member is to focus on the review of the study protocol while the role of the non-scientific or independent lay member is to focus on the review of the informed consent process and form.
b. The roles of the institutional and non-institutional (independent lay) members in terms of the review are similar, however, the non-institutional (independent lay) member is expected to provide an external perspective to ensure the independence of the position of the PSU Research Ethics Committee, even from possible bias posed by its own institution that may the impact rights, safety, and well-being of human subjects in research.
c. Makes a timely and thorough review and decision regarding protocols given to him/her for evaluation.
d. Familiarizes him/herself with the PSUREC Standard Operation Procedure (SOP), his/her terms of reference, and the international and national guidelines on research ethics.
e. Participates actively in the Committee meetings. It is expected that a member will have at least 80% attendance during the period of appointment because attendance is integral to the effectiveness of the committee as a review board.
f. Participates in the review of the progress reports, final reports, and other amendments presented during the ERC meeting.
g. Participates in Site Visits and similar activities as needed.
h. Maintains confidentiality of the documents and deliberations of committee meetings.
i. Declares any conflict of interest in general and for specific protocols for review.
j. Participates in required training with proof of attendance in such training activity submitted to the PSUREC.
k. Submits an updated and signed CV at the start of each calendar year.

l. Refers to the PSUREC Chair any suggestion, complaint, or grievance of research participants, and/or sponsors before acting on them.
m. Performs other PSUREC-related duties that may be requested of him/her by the Chair.

C. APPOINTMENT OF MEMBERS

Members shall be appointed by the REC Chair for a three-year renewable term. Members shall be appointed based on, but not limited to:

1. Their willingness to commit the time required for their duties on the Committee.
2. Their expert knowledge in medicine, science, or another field as appropriate.
3. Their willingness to acquire knowledge of research ethics through appropriate training and education within two months of beginning service on the Committee.

To ensure the independence of the REC and the ability of its members to exercise their judgement concerning matters coming before the REC, they may be removed from the REC by the Chair for the following grounds:

1. Failure to attend three consecutive meetings for which they had previously committed without informing the Secretariat in advance of the meetings.
2. Failure to attend at least 40% of the REC meetings in any given year.
3. Negligence to perform the functions expected of REC members, including serving as primary reviewer of assigned research proposals.
4. Flagrant departure from REC Standard Operating Procedure.
5. Receipt of any item of value as a means of influencing the decisions of the member regarding a submitted protocol.

In case of vacancy or resignation or termination of any member of the PSUREC:

1.The PSUREC Chair shall recommend to the University President for an advertisement to be placed at the PSU Website for the said vacancy.
2. The PSUREC Chair may admit recommendations from other members of any potential member. The chair will review the curriculum vitae and conduct an interview of the applicant for the position. The Chair will then recommend to the University President all qualified applicants for the position.
3.The University President will appoint the applicant for the position of a member of the PSUREC.

D. Committee Members

1. Mr. Diomerl Edward Baldo- Biology
2. Ms. Teresa Avila-Mendoza-Food Science
3. Ms. Rolan Jon Bulao- Economist
4. Ms. Francia Lisay- Clinician
5. Mr. Leo Constantino Bello-ICT
6. Mr. Patrick Edward Vergara-Biology
7. Ms. Sherry Combis- Communication
8. Mr. Kier Gasga-Chemical Engineer
9. Social Science
10. Lay Member (External)

E. DELIVERABLES

For the next two to three years, the Committee shall

1. Review and approve at least 10 research protocols (internal/ external)
2. Submit detailed annual report of the committee to the Philippine Research Ethics Board for renewal of accreditation and possible application for level 2 accreditation.
3. Have systematic filing, have adequate administrative support as shown by an assigned office with standard equipment, a budget that supports honoraria for and training of the REC members, and a functional database.
4. Be able to send

F. PROGRAMS AND FACILITIES

1. Research Programs

One of the requirements for the appointment of committee chair and members is the attendance and participation to various type of PHRED-SIDTA Research Ethics Training Programs. The committee has allotted budget to the following trainings:

a. Basic Research Ethics Training
   Content:
   i. Definition of Terms
   ii. Scientific Soundness
   iii. Research Ethics Principles (Beneficence, non-maleficence, autonomy, justice)
   iv. Declaration of Helsinki
   v. Research Ethics Review
   vi. Informed Consent
   vii. Authorship
   viii. Review of the Research Proposal
   ix. Ethics Review System
   x. Ethics Review Committees
   xi. Ethical Researcher

b. Good Research Practice
   Content:
   i. Definition of Terms
   ii. Review of different methodologies (eg social research)
   iii. Research Ethics Principles
   iv. Review of the research proposal
   v. Nuremberg code
   vi. National Ethics Guidelines
   vii. ERC-Organization, function, and responsibilities
   viii. Vulnerable population in research
   ix. SOPs

c. Advanced/focused workshop
   Content:
   i. SOPs
   ii. Conflict of Interests (COI)
   iii. Informed Consent
   iv. ERCs
   v. Training of trainers
   vi. Training of evaluators

2.Office Facilities

The committee shall have a dedicated office space, with basic equipment (computer with internet connection and printer, filing cabinets with locks), contents of the active and inactive cabinets or filing system, poster of the general flow chart of REC procedures, and a designated staff secretary.

G. BUDGETARY REQUIREMENTS (for year 1 of operation)

Particulars	**Amount** (PhP)
Salaries and Honorarium	
One (1) REC Secretary @ PhP11, 068/month x 12 months) /COS	132,816.00
Honoraria for External Member	100,000.00
Subtotal	*232,816.00*
MOOE	
Travel	20,000.00
Training Fees	300,000.00
Office Table	6,000.00
Supplies and materials, photocopying, binding	15,000.00
Filing Cabinet	15,000.00
Incidental Expenses	20,000.00
Subtotal	*376,000.00*
Capital Outlay	
Computer & Printer set	100,000.00
Subtotal	*100,000,00*
Grand Total	**708,816.00**

Source: Research Income 2022

V. EFFECTIVITY

The Establishment of Partido State University Research Ethics Committee shall take effect immediately upon the confirmation and approval of the Board of Regents.

VI. Proponents:

Prepared by:

DIOMERL EDWARD B. BALDO

PATRICIA M. CANDELARIA

VII. References:

National Ethical Guidelines for Health and Related Research 2017
PHREB Policies and Requirements for Accreditation of Research Ethics Committee
PHREB SOP Workbook 2020